- Mahua calls Dehadrai "a jilted ex", reprises old charge of Dubey being "a fake degree wala"; says charges are baseless vendetta

- Hiranandani files an affidavit incriminating Mahua; says she shared her LS account login/ password so he could directly pose questions

- Among the 'questionable questions': on **Adani**'s Dhamra LNG terminal. The Hiranandanis have competing interests in the area



years to set up a data centre campus in the state. Mahua, in response to his affidavit, alleged it was drafted by "some half-wit in the PMO" and signed with "a gun to the head", but added on a mock-sympathetic note: "Though tragic, it is totally understandable that Darshan (who is a dear friend) would need to think of what is at stake for him here." The rundown on the branded gifts that Dehadrai alleges Mahua got from Darshan added a touch of Page 3 glam to the story: 35 pairs of shoes from Salvatore Ferragamo, scarves from Hermes and Louis Vuitton and bags from Gucci and Berluti. Ranging upward in order of seriousness, the list allegedly also includes wine bottles, holidays, a redesign of her Lutyens' bungalow and, finally, cash. It's that last one, and the login/ password, that may prove the most damaging.

THE KEY QUESTIONS

Also, what she's alleged to have done in return. Dehadrai claimed that of the 61 questions posted by the TMC MP during her Lok Sabha tenure, some 50 related to the "business interests of Darshan Hiranandani and his company". The imputation: her questions on the Adani group—a later count whittled these down to 12—were actually meant to further the competing interests of the Hiranandanis. Three businesses where they have common interests are real estate, data centres and LNG terminals, although little was known of any rivalry between the two until this controversy. Darshan's affidavit, written in the tone of an approver-like confessional, has some potentially incriminating detail here. H-Energy, which he founded in 2017, has an LNG regasification terminal at Jaigrah Port in Maharashtra's Ratnagiri district. Indian Oil Corporation (IOC) and Gas Authority of India had tied up with the Dhamra LNG terminal in Odisha, a joint venture between the Adani group and French firm TotalEnergies, to import liquefied natural gas and regasify it. Darshan alleged that Moitra knew IOC "preferred to get into a long term off-take agreement with Dhamra", and not with his company. Based on this information, he alleged, she drafted queries that could "embarrass the government by targeting the Adani group.... She shared with me her email ID as Member of Parliament, so that I could send her information.... I went along with her proposal". Four of Mahua's 62 questions related to Dhamra port.

Darshan also widened the argument on another tangent to say Mahua deliberately targeted Modi and Union home minister Amit Shah, linking them to Adani, because she was a "very ambitious" politician who wanted to "quickly make a name for herself at the national level". The affidavit stated: "As was her wont, she thought that the only way to attack Modi is by attacking Gautam Adani and his group as both were contemporaries, and they belong to the same state of Gujarat." Mahua, in a tweeted response, strongly implied a concerted witch-hunt: "Chairman Ethics Committee openly speaks to the media. Please see Lok Sabha rules below. How does 'affidavit' find its way to the media? Chairman should first do an inquiry into how this was leaked. I repeat—BJP's 1 point agenda is to expel me from LS to shut me up on Adani." Another taunt went thus: "Also waiting for Enforcement Directorate and others to file FIR in Adani coal scam before coming to my doorstep."

A stronger rebuff, including threats of legal action, came from four other characters the affidavit had sought to enwrap within the Mahua story: lawyer couple Shardul and Pallavi Shroff, BJD MP Pinaki Misra and journalist Sucheta Dalal. In Darshan's signed narrative, they were named as part of a rolling cast of friends and acquaintances who sought to feed Mahua with explosive dope on Adani—or "unverified information", as he called it, which she could parlay into questions in Parliament. In response, Mahua herself cast the first stone by calling the affidavit a "joke" for trying to link "every opponent" of Modi-Shah-Adani to "me and my alleged corruption". She threw in some biting references to make her point. "Shardul Shroff is the brother of Cyril Shroff who has had a bitter separation of business from him. Cyril Shroff is Gautam Adani's '*samdhi*' and was on the SEBI's committee in total conflict of interest," she wrote, before going on to similarly pooh-pooh other imputed linkages. "Clearly someone said, *Sab ka naam ghusaa do, aisa mauka phir nahin aayega*!'"—that is, 'put in everyone's name, you won't get another chance like this'.

Between the precisely delivered upper-cuts and roundhouses, though, she was also taking some blows. The same day, her lawyer Gopal Sankaranarayanan—"NLSIU legend Gopal Shanks" to his admirers—was to withdraw sheepishly from her case. This was after Dehadrai revealed that he had quietly tried to buy a truce on Mahua's behalf over a 30-minute phone call with an offer they thought couldn't be refused: keep the dog, take back the CBI complaint.

But there was plenty cover fire coming from the others named in the affidavit. As it happened, they were no hapless pushovers who would take kindly to being damned by insinuation, leave alone be willing to roll over and die. Shroff runs a leading law firm with wife Pallavi, herself the daughter of former Chief Justice P.N.